extern



UI/UX DESIGN | PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

BeReal.

How friction, timing, and imperfection became a design system

Product design case study • 2026

Presented by Lashawn Fofung, MBA, PMP, CSM, CSPO

AGENDA

What we'll cover

01 **The product**

What BeReal is, and the numbers behind it

02 **The core mechanic**

Dual-camera capture and the 2-minute window

03 **Interaction teardown**

Onboarding, capture, feed, reactions

04 **Visual identity**

Typography, color, iconography

05 **What works, what doesn't**

Strengths, critique, and takeaways

THE PRODUCT

One photo. No filters. No do-overs.

BeReal is a French photo-sharing app built around a single daily ritual: when the notification fires, you have a short window to capture and post a simultaneous front-and-back camera photo of whatever you're doing — unedited.

40M+

active users at acquisition

2 min

daily posting window

€500M

Voodoo acquisition, 2024

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Authenticity over performance

Every mainstream social app of the 2010s optimized for the best possible version of a moment — filters, retakes, curation. BeReal's entire interface is engineered to work against that instinct.

- **No filters or beauty tools**
  Removes the editing layer other apps treat as core functionality
- **A visible retake counter**
  Turns a hidden behavior (redoing a photo) into public information
- **One post per day by default**
  Trades volume and virality for a single, unhurried ritual

> *The product doesn't ask “how do I look?” It asks “what are you actually doing right now?” — and the interface never gives you time to reconsider the answer.*

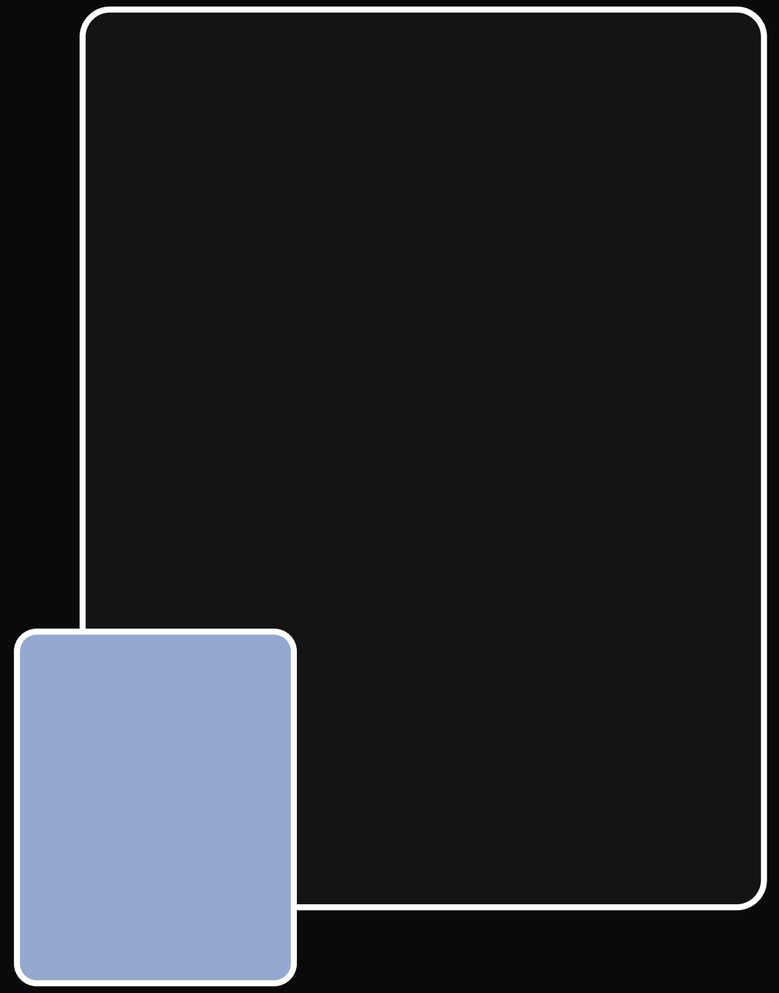
DESIGN TAKEAWAY

SIGNATURE INTERACTION

The dual-camera capture

One tap fires both cameras at once, stitching a small front-facing frame onto a larger back-facing shot. It's the single interaction the entire app is built around.

- Removes the choice of “which camera” — there's only one action
- The small frame is unavoidable proof of who's behind the big frame
- One tap = one artifact; nothing to compose or crop



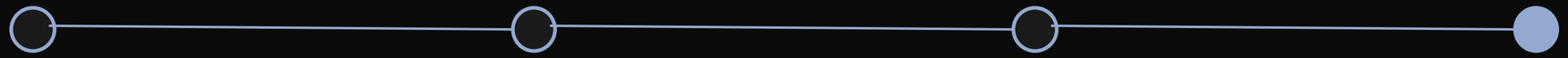
BACK CAMERA — FULL FRAME

FRONT CAMERA — OVERLAY

ENGAGEMENT MODEL

Notification as the entry point

There's no feed to scroll into on a whim. The randomized daily alert is the only door into the app — engagement is scheduled by the product, not requested by the user.



9:41 AM

Time picked at random, once per day

Push fires

“Time to BeReal.” No context, no preview

Window opens

Users capture within the moment, no scheduling

Late flag

Posting after the window is marked publicly

WHY IT WORKS

Scarcity replaces the infinite scroll: there's one chance a day, so opening the app is an event, not a habit loop.

INTERACTION TEARDOWN

Onboarding: friends before features

1. **Phone number sign-up**

   No email flow, no profile customization to slow the funnel

2. **Import contacts**

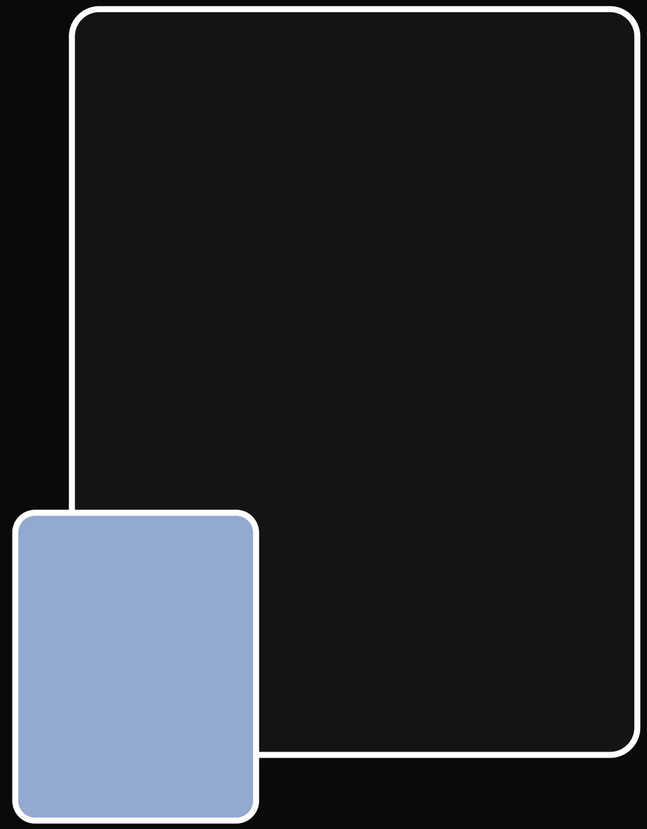
   Friend graph is built before the user ever sees the camera

3. **Permissions up front**

   Camera, location, and notifications requested immediately — the app is unusable without them

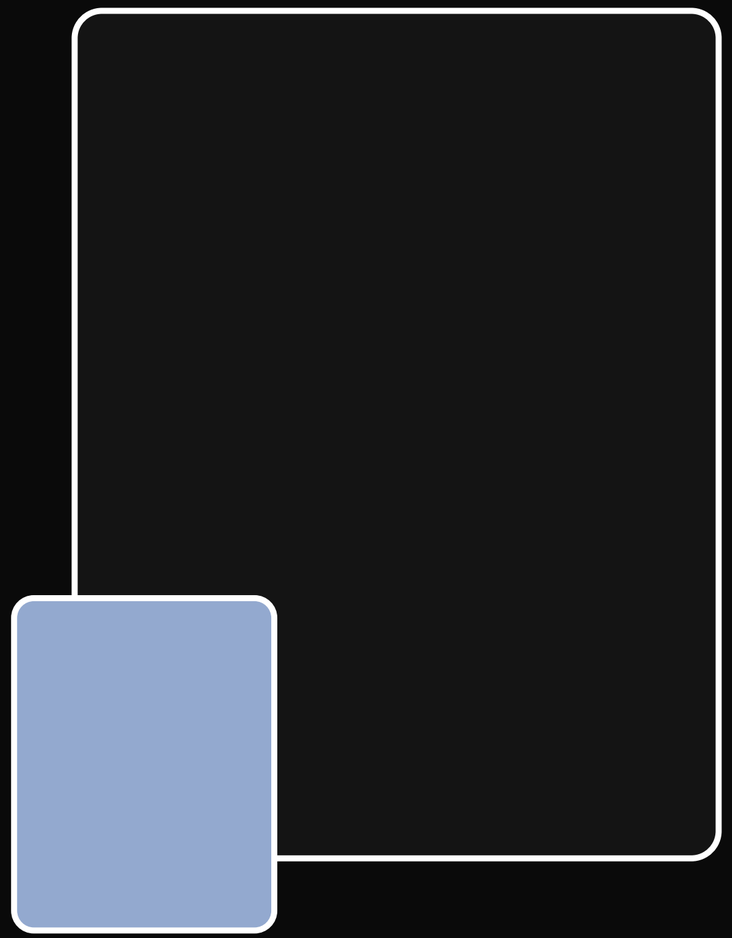
4. **Straight to capture**

   No sample feed, no tutorial video — the first real action is the product



INTERACTION TEARDOWN

The capture screen, annotated



1. **Full-bleed viewfinder**

   No chrome around the frame — the photo is the entire interface

2. **Single shutter button**

   Bottom-center, thumb-reachable, impossible to miss

3. **Countdown persists on-screen**

   Time remaining stays visible so urgency never fades

4. **Retake counter, top corner**

   Small and unobtrusive, but never hidden from the poster or their friends

INTERACTION TEARDOWN

Friction as a feature

Most products design friction out. BeReal designs specific friction in — and makes the evidence of that friction part of the social content itself.

Retake counter

Every retry is logged and shown next to the post — trying too hard is visible, not private.

Late badge

Posting after the window tags the photo as late, publicly trading spontaneity for participation.

Unlock-to-see gate

You can't view friends' posts until you've posted your own — friction that enforces reciprocity.

INTERACTION TEARDOWN

RealMoji vs. the traditional like

TRADITIONAL LIKE

- One universal icon for every reaction
- Anonymous at a glance in aggregate counts
- Optimized for speed — a single tap, no camera
- Reaction is decoupled from the reactor's identity

REALMOJI

- Reaction is a selfie reacting, not a stock icon
- Always attributed — your face is the reaction
- Slower by design: opens the camera to respond
- Turns reacting into its own small authentic moment

VISUAL IDENTITY

Typography that gets out of the way

The wordmark carries almost all of the brand's typographic personality; inside the product, type is quiet, bold, and utilitarian — it labels the interface, it never competes with the photo.

Heavy, rounded wordmark

Confident and friendly — the one place the brand allows itself flourish

Bold sans-serif UI type

High-weight labels stay legible over busy photo backgrounds

Minimal in-app copy

Short, lowercase, conversational microcopy (“time to be real.”)

BeReal.

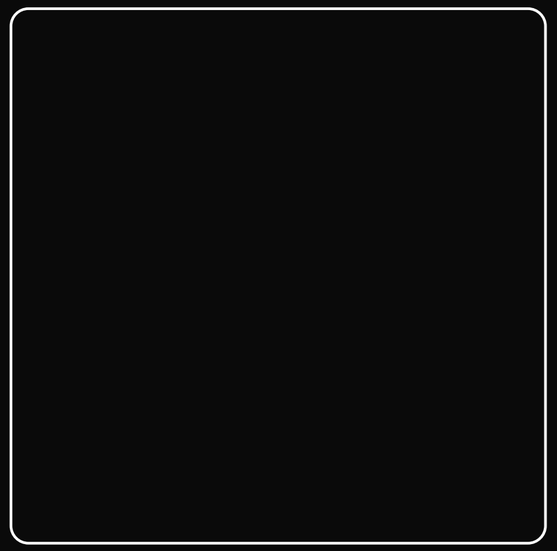
PRIMARY WORDMARK

Rounded terminals soften an otherwise blunt, heavy weight — bold but never aggressive.

VISUAL IDENTITY

A canvas built to disappear

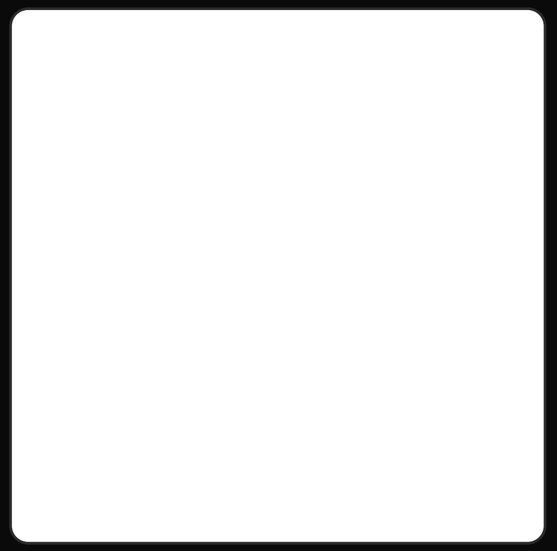
Near-black backgrounds behave like a darkroom: they recede so the photo — always full color, always the real subject — is the only thing that reads as content.



Canvas black

#0A0A0A

UI background, ~70% of surface area



Signal white

#FFFFFF

Primary text, borders, iconography



Accent yellow

#FFDE59

Single accent — CTAs, alerts, highlights



Muted gray

#2b2b2b

Secondary text, timestamps, captions

ASSESSMENT

What works well

Radical simplicity

One core action, no competing navigation — nothing to learn

Consistent motif

The dual-frame photo is instantly recognizable across every surface

Honest status signals

Retake counts and late flags build trust instead of hiding behavior

Low-effort participation

A single daily photo lowers the bar for showing up versus curated posts

ASSESSMENT

Where the model is under strain

Daily active use fell from about 15M to roughly 6M between late 2022 and spring 2023, and the product has since had to layer in features the original design deliberately avoided.

- **Novelty fatigue**

  A one-note ritual is hard to keep compelling once the format stops feeling new

- **Feature creep vs. purity**

  Groups, multiple posts, and a discovery feed all dilute the original single-post, friends-only rule

- **Monetization pressure**

  Voodoo's plans for ads and video sit in tension with a UI built on having nothing to scroll

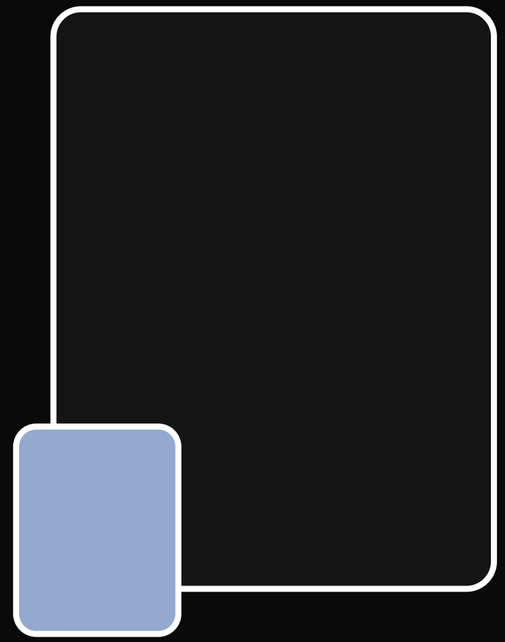
TAKEAWAYS

Lessons for product teams

1. Constraint can be the entire value proposition — removing options is a design decision, not a missing feature
2. Make the interaction the brand. BeReal's identity lives in one gesture, not a style guide
3. Visible friction (retakes, late flags) can build trust faster than hiding imperfection ever could
4. A single, well-defended ritual scales further than a feed of many mediocre ones — until it doesn't; know when to evolve

THANK YOU

Be real.
Not polished.



UI/UX Design Teardown — Prepared 2026

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